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Ruth Lion

Ruth Lion has held a lifelong passion for jazz and its artists. Her mother was a classical musician but the music of Jimmy Lunceford and Duke Ellington opened a new world of possibilities for Ruth. She found work as a jazz DJ in New York City and put records from the Blue Note label high on her playlist. Alfred Lion, founder of Blue Note, tracked this heavy airplay to its source and Ruth and Alfred were married shortly after. Blue Note became one of America's most respected labels and launched the careers of an impressive list of jazz artists. After Blue Note was sold to Liberty Records in 1966, Alfred and Ruth moved to Mexico for ten years, later settling in Ranch Bernardo, California. They became involved in Public Access productions for cable television, both in Mexico and San Diego. Since Alfred's passing in 1987, Ruth has remained active in this field and received the 1997 Best Public Access Award for her Jazz Library production on Duke Ellington.

Ruth Lion was interviewed in San Diego, California on February 15, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are interviewing today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive here in San Diego. And I am extremely pleased to have Ruth Lion with me, and we're going to talk about a lot of things, mostly about Blue Note Records. And just to get us started here —
[audio interlude]

MR: You couldn't do any better than to listen to Thelonious. It seems like sometimes the simplest things are the best, you know. And I think these gentlemen certainly understood that to some extent. I would like to ask you, before we get to Alfred and his vision of Blue Note Records, you must have been a jazz fan before you met him. Is that right?

RL: I was.

MR: How did you come to love jazz?

RL: Actually through my mother, who had the first African-American school of music in the United States, The Hansbury School of Music. And we had early wind-up Victrolas. My mother of course was in classical music, but she was not against jazz or any popular music. And with this wind-up Victrola my brother and I, I was six years of age, heard an Ellington, one of those, you know, it was "Blue Bubbles." And we just danced, and we were just so happy with that music. And I think I've been a jazz fan ever since then.

MR: Really touched something in you, huh?

RL: It really did.

MR: Were those 78s at that time? Or was it a ten inch?

RL: A 78, yes.

RL: That came about in the early '50s. There was a place in New York called the Palm Cafe. And I used to listen to them on the radio a lot. There was a guy there who was just a magnificent jockey, Jack Walker, and I thought well gee I'd love to do that. And I'd always been sort of PR, that type of work, but I was getting a little bored with it and so I thought well I'll go there and ask them if they'll hire me. And I did. And they hired me.

MR: Wow. What were you doing up to that point?

RL: Well up to that point I was married, and it was interesting being married, but not quite — I needed something that would keep me a little bit more out and involved. I was involved of course, I had children and all, but it just seemed to me that I needed to do something that was in me, which was the music. And I listened all the time, and I said well gee, I know this music, and I love it, and I can talk about it. And so I got a bunch of records and I made myself a little tape, a practice tape, and so I went and asked them for a job. I was surprised they did hire me.

MR: What kind of hours was your show on?

RL: Our show was called "Life Begins at Midnight." And this person that I learned from, Jack Walker, he just knew how to program so out of this world, and he was from Canada, and he had a voice that was just magnificent. And of course I admired all of that and it was a thrill working with Jack, and meeting people. I met, oh, prominent people. There was Dorothy Kilgallen who came in, and of course I've always been interested in public relations so I promoted our show and it got to be the top on the station.

MR: Did you have a freedom to choose what you wanted to play?

RL: Yes we did have the freedom to choose what we wanted to play. And of course before I met Alfred, all I wanted to play was Blue Note, and I did. And I guess that's why maybe he came in one night and wanted to know who's that crazy girl who plays so many Blue Notes. But I got to know him through being there I suppose. But I think it's more than that, I think I was supposed to get to know him.

MR: That this was a meeting that was fated to happen perhaps.

RL: Yes, I think so.

MR: And you told me that you liked him right away?

RL: Oh I loved him right away, absolutely. The first sight, that was it. It was like, you know, the boom.

MR: Yeah, wow, that's interesting. There you are playing his records, and there he is. Great.

RL: Yes. I feel that way. In fact, there was one Grant Green — and I just loved that "Am I Blue." And I said, "Alfred, I have to play this and play it and play it and play it because if you leave me, and I listen to that, and I haven't heard it, I wouldn't be able to handle it, so I listened and listened and listened. And after he's gone, I can't listen to "Am I Blue."

MR: Yeah. Well I'd like to talk for a moment about Alfred, coming from Germany, in the '30s, and whether or not the atmosphere, the social atmosphere that he lived in, do you think it had an effect on him looking for something else, and finding it in American jazz.

RL: I do believe so. Because Alfred had a very structured personality. He was a person who had come up in a very — he was raised in military schools, from a little kid, maybe five or six years of age. So everything — I mean he was meticulous in everything he did. So I think that when he was a kid, he went skating and he heard instead of there being skating that day, there was Sam Wooding, the orchestra, the old time orchestra. This was back in the 20s. So he went and listened to them. And he never got over that, that rhythm, that freedom, that soul, everything that was in that music. So he just, he began to collect records and then he and his friend Frank Wolf would play the records together, and then for some reason, because I guess of the political situation there, they had to separate and Alfred came to the States and Frank stayed. Because many people didn't believe it was as bad as it truly was. And Frank stayed and Alfred came here, and then in 1920 — no it was 1930, he went back and Frank still wanted to stay. So Alfred and his mother went to Chile and they stayed there for oh a number of years. I don't know the biography. I can tell you, when you interview Michael Cuscuna, he knows everything. I only know mine from the experience of it with him. But that was actually what happened. The rigidity I'll call it — the way, the culture was a very —

MR: Strict?

RL: Very strict. And he loved that free and easy way that the African Americans had at that time, and he wanted to be a part of it. And the way he could be a part of it, maybe in a little bit we'll go to, I'd like to say that he, through John Hammond he got to be a part of it.

MR: Oh I didn't realize John Hammond had a part in getting Alfred on the road to recording.

RL: A very, very big part in his life.

MR: Well let's talk about that. Because he finally came to the U.S. to stay, and that was what year? About what year? After Chile.

RL: I think that might have been about 1937. And he wanted to get more immersed, enmeshed in jazz. And he joined a club in New Jersey. He lived in New York. He joined a club in New Jersey. I don't know exactly what they called it, but it was a jazz — like people who just loved the music. And they collected the records and they played the records, and I mean they'd just go wild over what they were hearing. And so John Hammond gave a concert, and I do — someone sent me from Japan a copy of that concert, which — I've been too appreciative of it to even play it — but this is the concert that Alfred began Blue Note records with. Because he used to see John Hammond —

And Hammond thought well gee this guy's a little bit, what is it, you know, I mean he never stopped working. Alfred could do five things at the same time. And know what he was doing. So he met, he would see him in the post office, and so he said, "You know I'd like you to come and hear my concert at Carnegie Hall, 'Spirituals to Swing.' And Alfred said, "Oh I'd love to." And of course he went and there he happened to hear these two guys.

MR: Sure, they did the piano duets there.

RL: Yeah. Meade Lux Lewis and Albert Ammons. And so he went backstage. I can get a little bit of the feeling that he must have had. I mean because when you hear this record, even though today we might consider it dated but it had such a vitality to it. And Alfred being a person who reacted immediately to something that he really liked, he went backstage and he said, "I belong to a club of people who love jazz. Would you make a twelve-inch record so you wouldn't have to stop playing? You could just play and play and play." Because they only had, I think at that time, I don't know I really am not able to — I'm too excited to tell you, — but you could only play for maybe three minutes. And so he said, "You please come and play and you don't have to stop." So the guys said, "Well will you pay us?" And he said, "Well what will you charge?" They said, "A hundred dollars." So Alfred said, "Yes, I'll pay you." And he did. And he made the records, and he played them for his friends, and his friends all wanted copies, and more people wanted copies, and before he knew it, he was in Blue Note records. So that was John Hammond, whom I had the pleasure of talking with and really telling how much I appreciated his making that life possible. I don't think Alfred would have gotten into business had it not been for that.

MR: We talked a little bit on the phone a couple of times about what it was about African American musicians especially that seemed to attract him. Do you feel that it was a mission for him to promote their music and record it? Or what was it?

RL: I think it was that he was so interested in that particular musical expression. And I don't know that it was actually a mission any more than it was just something that he wanted to hear, and he wanted to — whoever else might want to hear it he'd like to give it to them. He was a very giving person. And I think that's what it was. And he couldn't hear enough of that music, you know, to please himself. So then he would go ahead and record these musicians. It was like Frank, his associate, put it in this way. The blues were always the basis of everything. And maybe the blues could be rhythmic and all, but there was always that sort of certain undercurrent of soul or religiosity, something of that sort that he would hear. And both Frank and Alfred were religious people. So that — the music was like for them, an expression of their own souls. So yes, he did record a number of non-African

MR: That's so hard to pin down, but saying in the same sentence "soul" and "blues" and "religious feeling," that makes a lot of sense to me, that it just — every one of those things has a certain thing that touches you in your heart, and obviously that this music just wouldn't let him go, right? He had to do this.

RL: He had to. He really did.

MR: So when the label was first launched, then the whole idea of distribution and selling it and all of that comes into play.

RL: It does.

MR: Did he have any experience in marketing? Did you have any experience in marketing that you later helped him with?

RL: Well yes I did public relations and artist promotion for him. However, himself he just had a natural intellect. He had, in Germany, learned accounting and he was just, as I said before, a very careful, caring person. His concentration was so that it couldn't be broken. I mean that was why I was saying that with Billie Holiday that, "Don't come into my recording session," and, "I mean we're here for business." And what Dexter Gordon said, "You just have to play better for Blue Note." When the guys came on a Blue Note date, they knew, everybody was going to do their best. You know they loved him and they wanted to do their best. And they did. That's why so many of the records are considered very, very much classic.

MR: That's a very high compliment, to get that from the musicians themselves, that they wanted to do their best. Who were some of the very first artists that he was able to record?

RL: Well among the first who became very popular, I think we have a picture maybe we can show of Sidney Bechet. You knew – he had a great career in France, and of course he came here and he was recognized too. But maybe we'll show these later. But here we have him looking — Frank took this picture in France. He became French.

MR: Yes. He had a street named after him and everything, right?

RL: And now let's see if I have another Bechet. But however, going on, I don't want to hold things up this way, but some of the other artists were — oh gee at the moment I can hardly think — but —

MR: How many records would they actually print the first time around?

RL: Those are things I never paid a lot of attention to, you know, that business side, I didn't pay too much attention to. I'm sorry.

MR: That's all right. And when you said you promoted the artists—

RL: Yes.

MR: How did you go about doing that? Was it through trying to get airplay and all that?

RL: Airplay. Particularly. And I recall on the 25th anniversary of Blue Note, I had a lot of buddies who were radio people, and we invited them all, we had a party at The Playboy Club. And about three times more people than we invited, radio people came. But that was very indicative of the fact that the music was very popular. New York was very jazz oriented at that time. And so you had no trouble — I'd take the artist to the programs and — I've forgotten the first coast to coast program we had, who did we have — Duke Pearson. But anyway it was coast to coast, and we did that. And then we got on the Steve Allen Show with the Jazz Messengers, which was very momentous, and very exciting. And the little guys they had their little, at that time they wore the Nehru jackets you know, those high jackets you know, and they were just so fabulous.

MR: Let's talk about Art Blakey for a minute.

RL: Oh yeah, Art Blakey. Well Blakey was, in my opinion, maybe the most exemplary of the Blue Note artists, because he did express what Alfred was looking for, which was that rhythm. And they had a great relationship — Blakey was just like his brother. And the Jazz Messengers, I have something I'd like to show you of that later, but that was one of the most successful of the records of the 50s, when they did Birdland, "One Night at Birdland," and then they followed -- that was so successful with Blakey and Horace Silver, and Kenny Dorham, and gee I don't remember all the guys, but that is a classic record. And then they followed that up by going to the Bohemia, the Club Bohemia, and I remember that one particularly well because Blue Note had begun to attract attention because it was beginning to make hits. And I guess that's attention getting, gathering. Well that night, Rudy Van Gelder, who was the engineer, and he got the Blue Note sound, he and Alfred got together and got that sound that's very distinctive, you only hear it on Blue Note. And he had all his equipment here and then Alfred and Frank were running all over the place, but it seemed that every record executive in town showed up that night. Because they wanted to see what's happening here. But it was a glowing night and it was fantastic, still one of my favorite records. You know "One Night at the Cafe Bohemia." And that was Art Blakey, that was a very young Horace Silver, and I can hear that music at night — I'm sleeping and I hear it. It was so firey, so original, never heard before. And Kenny Dorham, and of course he was one of the great trumpeters of Blue Note.

MR: It's almost like it could have been the Art Blakey jazz school too.

RL: It was. And it became that. You know Wynton Marsalis was with Blakey towards the end.

MR: And Wayne Shorter and all those guys.

RL: Wayne Shorter, yeah. Yeah Blakey was a great teacher and he was still very patient you

and he let you expand so I heard from the fellows. You could do and he'd let you come out.

MR: He must have encouraged the guys to write too.

RL: I'm sure he did.

MR: Because look at all the great tunes that just came out. Yeah. He's quite a legacy just on his own.

RL: Yes he is.

MR: Well I was also wondering about the tough times for Blue Note. Was there tough times? I mean when you look at Blue Note, you go oh, man, what a successful label. And unless you really know the realities of the record business, were there tough years for you guys?

RL: From the very beginning to the very end it was tough. It was an independent label they were battling the giants all the way. If they wanted to get Miles Davis, they had to get Miles Davis by way of Cannonball Adderley. One of the best, or most outstanding hits they had, was, I've forgotten the name of it —

MR: The early Cannonball, one of the early Cannonball records?

RL: The one where Cannonball plays with Miles Davis.

MR: Yeah. I think it's called "A Portrait of Cannonball" or something. It's got that "Autumn Leaves?"

RL: Yeah.

MR: Right.

RL: Well that came about only because they permitted Miles to be a sideman. Can you imagine Miles being a sideman? And so but Miles actually truly was the leader, but he did go ahead and do it. And if course it came out magnificently well. And speaking of the guys having great respect for Alfred and his musical — I'm just going to say it, it's true, genius. At the end of "Autumn Leaves," Miles said to Alfred, "Is that what you wanted, Al?" He knew he'd done it you know.

MR: "Is that what you wanted, Al?" Interesting.

RL: Very, very.

MR: There was a major switchover when the twelve inch LP came in. Did that hit you guys pretty hard?

RL: Very, very. And all that stock.

MR: You couldn't sell it anymore, ooh, wow. Did that switchover come as a complete surprise?

RL: Almost completely. Very much like the CDs today. You know people thought tapes were going to — you know we put them in the car and they're wonderful and everything. You know that came pretty fast.

RL: One night he got in the bed to go to sleep, and I had gotten to sleep. He got up and he walked the floor all night. And he decided the next day he would get a loan and he'd go ahead and persevere. He was ready to give up.

MR: Did you have to take music that had already been recorded and re-press it? Was that what the loan was for? Or was it to get new equipment to go to the twelve inch?

RL: It was to just carry on. Because truthfully, you're asking about tough times. I don't ever remember Blue Note being more than six months away from bankruptcy. It was tough, hard times. Work, but love for the work.

MR: And all those years you lived in New York?

RL: Yes.

MR: Yeah. That's where it was happening.

RL: It was happening. Out here on the coast there were a lot of things happening and he got to know some of the people who were recording. You know it's a very small industry. Everybody knows what everybody else is doing. And he liked what he was hearing, but he couldn't get into that, and he appreciated those who were — you know, Dave Brubeck, John [Paul] Desmond — the different guys who were great artists, but he could hardly get the guys that he had, you know? They were being taken away. You know the story about Jimmy Smith? He had Jimmy Smith and as soon as he became a star, off he went to a big label.

MR: Oh that has to be frustrating.

RL: Terrible.

MR: You know it's like your children, nurturing them and boom, then they're gone.

RL: Yeah.

MR: Did you two have a chance to experience the 52nd Street heyday in New York?

RL: Yes, very much so, yeah. From one club to another and it was absolutely divine. You could hear everybody: Charlie Parker, Dizzy Gillespie, Erroll Garner, yeah. It was — somehow you were aware that this was tremendous, but you didn't realize that it had its time like everything.

MR: Right.

RL: Yeah, but it was magnificent. You could walk in and hear — all those clubs. You could just walk in and just hear the most wonderful music.

MR: Were there ever any really difficult recording sessions that you attended, that just either didn't happen or somehow miraculously did come through but it didn't look like they were?

RL: I would say, I don't know what the percentage is, but his standards were so high that often times he'd write on the master, the mother, he'd write, "This record not good

MR: And the musicians were getting paid what the union scale—

RL: And more.

MR: And more?

RL: And more.

MR: He treated them right, is that correct?

RL: He was the soul of honesty and givingness. I'm not just saying that because he was the love of my life. I can be objective in when I look and see, and I saw it. The man was just a beautiful person.

MR: Well let's take a look at some of the other things you have here. Because I wanted to look at this photo. Can you tell me what year this was?

RL: That photo was in 1956. And we had gone to Birdland. He didn't have — sometimes he'd have three sessions in a week. And we had gone there and we were listening. I don't recall who we were listening to that night, but on the scene and enjoying it. And Teddy Reig, who he knew quite well, joined us at the bar, and someone came by and said, "Oh can we take your picture?" and they did. And that's how that happened. But yeah that Birdland was a beautiful place in those days. They had the top talent. And Bud Powell, I had a very nice experience — I was doing as I say PR for Blue Note at the time. And Bud had come over and the gentleman, Francis Paudras, who was his, I guess you might say patron, and he was there. And I remember we were upstairs in a room that they had provided for Alfred and Frank and this gentleman, Mr. Paudras, to confer. And Bud was really quite — he wasn't too well mentally, but he still played very, very well. And I recall that that took place at Birdland. And I was into giving awards. That was part of what I did. As I was telling you, times were tough, and while I worked for Blue Note, I also worked for a beer company, whom I talked into a promotion with jazz.

MR: No kidding? Tell me about that.

RL: And so I said you know we have some wonderful artists in town, and I'd like to give some awards, and those artists are Lionel Hampton, Bud Powell and Jimmy Smith. And they got the awards together, and I went and presented these awards through their auspices. And the one for Bud Powell was done at Birdland, the one for Jimmy Smith was done at the Apollo Theater, and the one for Lionel Hampton was done at the Metropole, which was a club at that time. So those were, you know, sort of everything happened at night. Things, like to me, eleven o'clock at night is very late now you know. Four o'clock in the morning was just the beginning of the morning at that time — beginning of the — so we would run around and do these things. So I had the pleasure of making these awards to these three artists. But Bud Powell was the one that I appreciated the most, because I've been into mental health for fifty years, and I want to see us all

well. And I knew he was troubling. And so to give him some recognition while he was still with us, meant a lot to me.

MR: Good moment. Let me put on a piece of music for you.

RL: Thank you.

[audio interlude]

MR: I'm wondering when certain records were made, if you and Alfred had a feeling that this is going to be — you know — really good. This is going to be really good. This one's going to sell a lot of records.

RL: But always wrong.

MR: Always wrong?

RL: Always.

MR: No kidding.

RL: That one — nobody knew that "The Sidewinder" was going to make it.

MR: No.

RL: No. It took off and then they had to press more of course. But no. He had it on the beginning of the records, maybe he had hoped. But the public, in my opinion, cannot be predicted. And so you know for one that was just magnificent, Donald Byrd, "I'm Trying to Get Home." They spent money that they really were very unhappy to spend that much money and they wanted it to be the gigantic thing that it should have been but it didn't. It was great. Wonderful music with Coleridge Perkinson as the one who took care of the voices, and that was 18 vocals and the musicians. And even he was so uptight about it that when he was supposed to have Stanley Turrentine to do the saxophone, he says, "Suppose Stanley can't make it, then everything will go—" And so I said, "Why don't you do like the movies do and get a stand-in?" And he got a stand-in who didn't actually come and play, but he got that stand-in and that became one of his favorites, Joe Henderson.

MR: Oh, my.

RL: He was just beginning on the scene at that time.

MR: Joe Henderson was standing in for Stanley Turrentine.

RL: Well but he didn't — I mean now maybe that's an inside story, I don't know.

MR: Well that's interesting.

RL: Yeah, I think so. Because he and Alfred — I think maybe one of the reasons that we eventually got into Public Access television is they always thought that records were just like a part of a visual thing. Because they loved live music. So television would be the next best thing. But somehow music, jazz has not taken to television. Why I don't know.

MR: Yeah. That's really too bad. A number of people have mentioned that, that it's such a

Especially to reach young people. But I think it's interesting that this song, that it did become so popular. It's still blues, it's based on the blues, you know, and it's got that groove.

RL: What else?

MR: It's got that groove.

RL: Yeah.

MR: And you could dance to it. Great stuff. Tell me about the decision to eventually sell Blue Note and did you guys feel good about that? Was it time to do that?

RL: The time to do it was actually five years before it was done. Frank had become ill and Alfred also. And they struggled along for five years, trying to hang on, and they could not find a buyer. It was tough. And finally after many, many efforts in that direction, a gentleman from California came, from Liberty Records, and bought Blue Note. And of course it was a sad day for Alfred and Frank, and even though Frank was seriously ill, he died soon after, he decided to stay working for Liberty — pardon me, no I'm not correct there — he continued to work, and then Liberty sold to United Artists. And Frank continued. And Frank made some — he produced some gorgeous records. And then he became seriously ill in '72 and by that time Alfred and I had retired to Mexico. But I think truly Alfred never got over being out of Blue Note.

MR: Now as we look back on it, it is such a wonderful legacy that the fact that it eventually was sold, I don't think it matters now. I think, look at what the product was. Priceless. And one thing we didn't even bring up, really yet, is the marvelous photography that is such a part of that. And I'm curious if Frank ever experimented with color, with his photography? Did he ever shoot in color? Because most of it's all black and white, his photos, and they work so well.

RL: He thought, I believe, that black and white was more artistic. And he did experiment toward the last, and then of course when Blue Note was sold to United Artists and he did more in color. And I have those also. But I prefer the black and white because I think they express the soul of the artist. You know, he was looking for that. He would stand with his light and looking over, he would stand forever, to get that shot he wanted to get. And when you see those pictures you know, they're really art.

MR: Yes, absolutely. It's a whole other contribution of Blue Note, that those photographs stand on their own. To have that with the music, hey, there is heaven. That's great. We had looked at some of the gold records and so forth, and really great mementos that you have from those days. Tell me about the tribute in Japan.

RL: It would be my pleasure to tell you, because that was something I didn't understand. In 1984 we had relocated here in San Diego from Mexico. We spent eleven years in Mexico

Mexican radio. And we came here and Alfred was very interested in television. We did more psychological programs. He was more, because I guess he felt well you supported me at Blue Note, now you're into psychology, let's do your psychology programs. So he did. He supported me in that. And we had gone downtown to meet two psychological friends of mine. And it got very hot, one of those days in August, early August in '84. And we came back and we were getting ready to turn the corner to go home, and I saw him — we were talking, we always talked — he slumped over. And I didn't know what to do. I've got to get to the hospital. And so I started blowing the horn hard and going about maybe 80 miles an hour, and got to the hospital and spoke to the — ran in and said my husband's had a heart attack, and the lady came out yelling "Code Blue" and they got him there, and so then he did live that night, but they told me that he might not make it. He needed bypass surgery if he survived. And he did the next day, he was Alfred.

MR: No kidding.

RL: Yeah. He was laying there with these things tying him down and everything, and he says, "Get these things off of me." I was so glad for his temper to come back you know. And so he didn't want to get the bypass. He was too scared of it. And it was at that time very new. So there was something called chelation therapy that one of his friends had told him about, and so he decided he'd do that. And I'm glad he did, because he would have never gotten to Japan otherwise I don't think. He took the chelation therapy for several months and his personality, he never lost this terrific mind that he had, but his body got a little weak. Not too weak, you know, because he was — ummm. But he got a telegram from Bruce Lundwall at Blue Note, no, at Capitol Records. "We're going to have Blue Note now, and we're going to introduce the label." And so we went to New York for that, which was pretty terrific for him to do, a man who'd had cardiac arrest and been given up for dead you know. And we went there and we went through all — did I show you the cover where the musicians were with him?

MR: Yeah. I think that's here.

RL: That was a magnificent time of his life. I know that meant the world to him. Here he is. And these are the guys, so many of the guys that he loved. There's Bruce Lundwall. I don't think Michael Cuscuna — Bobby Hutcherson, Kenny Burrell, Jimmy Smith, so many of the guys. And so he went through that. It was an ordeal. But the last day that we were there, Reid Miles by the way went over on the plane with us, which was wonderful because Reid was a riot. This guy, he was absolutely as wild as Alfred and Frank. And these are like wild men I'm talking about. They were just not the average person. But anyway, that last day, Leonard Feather who was our close, dear friend, and a number of people were giving us a go-away breakfast. And among those people were five people

they were. And so they were very kind to us and everything. And then we went back home and he got word that they would like to have the Blue Note Festival at Mount Fuji. Well right away I said, "Alfred, no way, we can't do that." I mean we want to live, don't we? Well I'll have to show you this picture of him when his 70 — this was after cardiac arrest, I want to show you how good he looked, with the little blue suit on. He was a dandy, you know? This guy loved clothes. And so you see you remember that song Elvis used to sing, the "Blue Suede Shoes?" There they are too.

MR: Well I'll be darned.

RL: And he had been — but anyway we celebrated his birthday and we went over to our favorite place in LaJolla and celebrated. And I have a hundred pictures of Alfred. But anyway, these guys told him that they wanted him to come and they were going to have the Blue Note Festival at Mount Fuji. And I just had to be as firm as I could, "We're not going to do it." Well he went, you know he knew I liked him to dress up, which he loved to dress up anyway. He went and he got himself all gorgeous. And we had a little patio. And I'm sitting there, and he comes out on the patio and he puts his hands on his hips, and he says, "I don't know about you, maybe you're not going, but I'm going to Japan." Well I couldn't say no.

MR: That was pretty definite.

RL: He looked too fabulous with his little outfit that he had on, he had beige, and that was my favorite color on him, and he loved blue. And so I just said well I can't win this one, and I have to let it go, and so we went. And it was very difficult because he got ill on the plane and we had to sit down in Hawaii and stay there for three days while he got better, and then we went to there and they were kind enough to have a medical doctor in the suite next to us, who was on call 24 hours, stayed with us and saw that he had oxygen and everything. But he went through that whole — this picture here, this one I'd like to show, this was in a restaurant they took us to. Now this guy, this doesn't look like a mortally ill person, does it. He died three months later. But at that festival, Herbie Hancock was there, Lou Donaldson was there, they got everybody that Alfred loved. And it was wonderful. But three thousand people got up and gave him a standing ovation. And I think that's why I have heard it said that that's why he didn't die August 8th from that cardiac arrest. That he would have that. Because there are no fans, in my opinion, like the Japanese fans. They knew the song — I mean whatever it was they'd be going along with the song and everything. It was wonderful. And the people who were there, Dr. Ogawa and Mr. Namacoti and gee I can't recall at the moment, it was like a life beyond life. And so those people will always live in my heart, if I can't remember their names.

MR: Well gee, that's, and you've had, since Alfred passed, you have gotten into another dimension of entertainment with your Cable Access work, and I wanted to congratulate you on your award, from the PACE organization.

RL: Thank you.

MR: And you must really enjoy working.

RL: I do. I learned that. I always enjoyed working. But I learned it from him because he was so in love with his work. In fact on his gravestone I had printed "Through jazz he lived the life he loved." And I learned that from him. You don't always feel like working. But if you love that work you'll go ahead and do it, sick or well.

MR: Right. It's fortunate when you can work at what you love. Not everyone is able to do that.

RL: Not everyone. But I think even so, maybe that's why the arts have become so prominent today. Because everybody can have something that they enjoy, of the arts. Whether it's painting or sculpting or music, whatever it might be, you can add that dimension to your life and enjoy your life. Because we can't all be into one thing that is a full life.

MR: Right. Do you listen to current artists coming out these days?

RL: I do. I have to say reluctantly that I listen not as much as I want to. I will be doing more listening, but at the present time I am more looking to produce quality television, and so I focus more on that. I do try to present music. I'm currently editing a big band, it's a San Diego concert jazz band, I'm currently editing that. And that music is what I hear every day. So I'm sort of a focused person, so the music that's wonderful today, yes, I try my best to keep up somehow with it. But I get kind of side tracked with television.

MR: Do you still take an interest in the careers of people like Joe Henderson that are still out there?

RL: Sure. Herbie Hancock, Horace Silver, all the guys, Wayne Shorter, sure. I'm very interested and I'm always trusting that they continue for a long time.

MR: Is there anything that you would like to add about the Blue Note experience or that I haven't touched upon?

RL: No, you have been so wonderful to bring out Blue Note today for me, and I think there's nothing I can add except thank you, very much.

MR: Well it's been a real pleasure for me, and I appreciated being interviewed the other day too and we'll probably just both look at these tapes. It's been a real enjoyable trip out to San Diego here. And you know, San Diego has some good musicians itself.

RL: Oh, hasn't it?

MR: Yes. And I've managed to meet some of them so it's been a wonderful experience, and a great pleasure to meet you. So thank you very much.